

Market Square Redevelopment

Willow Creek — Project file | Launch date: October 5, 2023 | Budget: \$500,000

Project Overview

Market Square redevelopment is a strategic urban planning project valued at \$500,000, with launch planned for October 5, 2023. The initiative aims to transform this central public space into a dynamic and attractive place that stimulates local commerce while improving residents' quality of life.

Context and Rationale

Current condition of the square

Although Market Square sits in the historic heart of Willow Creek, it currently faces several issues: an outdated spatial layout, aging street furniture, a lack of welcoming gathering areas, and limited accessibility. The weekly market held there has gradually lost appeal, which affects both business activity and downtown vitality.

Preliminary studies

Resident consultations conducted in recent months revealed strong demand for a more welcoming, greener space that better supports commercial, cultural, and community activities. Economic analysis also shows that a high-quality redevelopment could increase downtown foot traffic by 25% and encourage new businesses to open.

Expected benefits

- revitalization of local commerce, with an expected 15% increase in revenue;
- greater visitor appeal for the historic downtown;
- stronger social connection through a shared space for meeting and exchange;
- enhancement of surrounding architectural heritage;
- development of outdoor cultural and event programming.

Detailed Project Description

Design concept

The project is built around the concept of a “multifunctional garden square,” combining aesthetics, functionality, and sustainability. The new layout will create dedicated areas for markets, café terraces, cultural events, and relaxation while preserving the historical identity of the place. The design will draw on traditional local architecture while introducing contemporary elements.

Main elements

- new local natural-stone paving with reinterpreted traditional patterns;
- creation of an interactive central fountain as a signature architectural element;
- installation of modular kiosks for market vendors;
- a versatile stage area for cultural events;
- trees and climate-adapted plantings to create shaded areas;
- comfortable and innovative street furniture, including benches, tables, and bike racks;
- low-energy architectural and ambient lighting;
- integrated power and water supply systems for vendors and events.

Technical and sustainable innovations

- permeable paving to support stormwater management;
- automatic irrigation using collected rainwater;
- smart lighting that adapts to time of day and foot traffic;
- street furniture made from recycled and locally sourced materials;
- solar-powered charging points for electronic devices;
- free public Wi-Fi covering the entire square.

Implementation Plan

Work phasing

To minimize the impact on commercial activity, the work will be carried out in three separate phases:

- 1 Phase 1 — 3 months: preparatory work and underground utilities.
- 2 Phase 2 — 4 months: redevelopment of the northern section, including the fountain and green areas.
- 3 Phase 3 — 3 months: redevelopment of the southern section and final finishing work.

Throughout construction, a temporary arrangement will keep the weekly market operating at a nearby alternative site.

Detailed schedule

- final studies and bidding process: October to December 2023;
- start of construction: January 2024;
- end of phase 1: March 2024;
- end of phase 2: July 2024;
- end of phase 3: October 2024;
- official opening: late October 2024, aligned with a traditional local celebration.

Stakeholders and governance

- Planning Department: project ownership and coordination;
- landscape architecture firm: design and construction monitoring;
- business association: consultation and information relay;
- downtown residents' council: resident representation;
- heritage committee: protection of historical identity;
- visitor services team: integration of tourism aspects.

Risk management

- archaeological risk: preliminary testing before work begins;
- budget overrun: 10% contingency reserve;
- impact on business activity: communication and compensation plan;
- adverse weather: schedule adapted with time buffers.

Economic and Commercial Dimension

Commercial revitalization strategy

- redesign of the weekly market organization with themed programming;
- seasonal commercial animation program;
- incentives for new businesses around the square;
- creation of a visual identity and storefront guidelines;
- development of a mobile app dedicated to downtown businesses.

Cost-benefit analysis

The \$500,000 investment is expected to generate the following economic impacts:

- 8% increase in commercial tax revenue from the first year;
- 15 to 20 direct and indirect local jobs;
- 5% to 10% increase in value for surrounding properties;
- 15% increase in visitor traffic during peak season.

Funding model

- municipal budget: \$300,000 (60%);
- regional downtown revitalization grant: \$150,000 (30%);
- private partnerships and local sponsors: \$50,000 (10%).

Social and Cultural Dimension

Event programming

The redeveloped square will become a permanent community hub, with:

- an upgraded traditional weekly market;
- monthly themed markets, such as organic producers and local crafts;
- seasonal cultural programming, including concerts, street theater, and exhibitions;
- participatory intergenerational activities;
- festive events marking key moments throughout the year.

Inclusion and accessibility

- full accessibility for people with reduced mobility;
- signage adapted for visually impaired users;
- integrated play areas for children;
- shaded rest areas for older residents;
- discounted access for selected events where applicable.

Impact on social cohesion

- intergenerational and intercultural encounters;
- positive community ownership of public space;
- a stronger sense of local pride and belonging;
- resident participation in town life.

Communication Strategy

Before and during construction

- quarterly public information meetings;
- on-site digital information board showing project progress;
- monthly newsletter for nearby residents and business owners;
- guided site visits for schools and associations;
- regular reporting in the municipal newsletter and local media.

Launch communication

- “Your New Square” campaign across print and digital channels;
- historical documentation comparing the square over time;
- before-and-after photo contest with resident participation;
- festive inaugural event involving local stakeholders.

Ongoing communication

- interactive kiosk presenting the square’s history and evolution;
- integrated signage telling the story of local heritage;
- widely distributed quarterly event program;
- active social media presence with a dedicated hashtag.

Evaluation and Monitoring

Performance indicators

- daily and weekly foot traffic;
- number and diversity of businesses participating in the market;
- sales trends for surrounding businesses;
- occupancy rate of terraces and commercial spaces;
- number and quality of events organized;
- user satisfaction measured through regular surveys.

Post-completion governance

After completion, a square committee made up of elected officials, business owners, residents, and technical staff will meet quarterly to analyze performance indicators, propose adjustments, program activities and events, and maintain the participatory momentum.

Conclusion

Market Square redevelopment is a structuring project for the future of Willow Creek. Beyond the physical transformation of a public space, the goal is to create new commercial, social, and cultural energy in the heart of the town. Through its inclusive and sustainable design, the reinvented square will embody the town’s values while responding to today’s urban-planning challenges. It will become a symbol of a lively, attractive, and welcoming downtown where people want to meet, spend time, and connect.